

In April 1961, President Kennedy ordered the dispatch of 400 Green Berets to South Vietnam from the First Special Forces Group based on Okinawa island, Japan. Captain Ron Shackleton and half of Detachment A-113 were tasked with setting up the Civil Irregular Defense Group (CIDG) program designed to protect the Montagnards, the mountain tribespeople, from infiltration by the Viet Cong. Kennedy also authorized the launch of a clandestine campaign against North Vietnam by South Vietnamese troops trained and directed by Special Forces advisers.

The Special Forces presence expanded rapidly, commanded from the fall of 1962 by Colonel George C. Morton. Their presence did not go unnoticed by the insurgents. In January 1963, the border surveillance camp at Plei Mrong became the first Special Forces camp to be assaulted by the Viet Cong.

By October 1964, there were 44 Special Forces Operational Detachments Alpha, also known as A-Teams, in South Vietnam, of which 28 were deployed on border surveillance, with the aim of preventing Viet Cong infiltration from Laos or across the Demilitarized Zone (DMZ). The results were mixed. Most infiltrators sought alternative routes, or simply avoided the Special Forces' patrols. In addition, the camps were hard to maintain and mostly only accessible by air. Ninety percent of the troops assigned to them had to be flown in or dropped by parachute, along with their supplies. The CIDGs that the Green Berets organized were more successful. The American hope was that these would prevent infiltration by the Viet Cong across the Central Highlands.

The Green Berets were not the only US special operations forces in Vietnam. The Navy Seals (Sea-Air-Land) specialized in riverine missions from 1962.

Regimental badge
with the motto
"de oppresso
liber"—to free
the oppressed



Badge of pride

This beret was worn by a member of the Seventh Special Forces Group Airborne, which trained the South Vietnamese army. In combat, caps or helmets replaced berets.

“The Green Beret is ... a symbol of
excellence, a badge of **courage**, a mark of
distinction.”

PRESIDENT JOHN. F. KENNEDY, MEMORANDUM TO THE US NAVY, APRIL 11, 1962